

CARFINDER

Marketing, SEO & Analytics Plan

Capstone Progress Check



Produced by: Amoy Turner

Full Sail University

Project and Portfolio VI: Web Development

September 2026

Executive Summary

CarFinder is a React web application designed to make searching and exploring vehicle inventory simple and organized. Users can search for vehicles by year, make, and model and view important information about available vehicles in one place. The application also integrates vehicle data from the National Highway Traffic Safety Administration (NHTSA) vPIC API to support the search experience. CarFinder is currently in its Beta stage, with its core search, vehicle details, inventory creation, navigation, API integration, and major user flows already functional. The project is now moving into the final stages of testing, optimization, and preparation for launch.

This plan outlines how CarFinder will reach its intended audience through marketing, improve its visibility through search engine optimization (SEO), and use analytics to measure how visitors find and interact with the application. The marketing strategy focuses on practical, low cost methods that can reach vehicle shoppers, researchers, and automotive enthusiasts, while the SEO strategy uses specific search terms that match CarFinder's actual features and purpose. Analytics will be used to measure traffic sources, vehicle searches, page engagement, and other user interactions. Together, these strategies will help determine whether CarFinder is reaching the right audience, how users are interacting with the application, and what improvements can be made as the project moves toward its final launch.

Project Overview

CarFinder is a React web application designed to provide users with a simple and organized way to search vehicle inventory by year, make, and model and view detailed vehicle information. Built with React, React Router, Vite, JavaScript, HTML, and CSS, the application also integrates the NHTSA vPIC API for vehicle make and model data. The current Beta includes vehicle search, filters, vehicle detail pages, inventory creation, local storage, Favorites, dashboard navigation, and a responsive layout, with future development planned for authentication, database storage, improved Favorites, VIN decoding, recall and safety information, and other improvements.

Target Audience and Positioning

CarFinder is designed for users who want a simple way to search and explore vehicle information. Instead of trying to compete directly with large automotive marketplaces, the focus is on providing a straightforward search experience built around year, make, and model.

Primary Audience Vehicle Shoppers	Secondary Audience Auto Enthusiasts	Administrative Audience. Inventory Managers
People researching vehicles, comparing options, or considering a future purchase. Their main need is a simple way to search inventory and quickly view useful vehicle information.	People who enjoy exploring different vehicles, makes, and models, even when they are not actively shopping. This audience may also benefit from future features such as VIN decoding, recall information, and safety ratings.	Users responsible for adding and maintaining vehicle inventory. This audience will become more important as CarFinder expands with manager permissions and database backed inventory.

Positioning Statement

CarFinder provides a simple and organized way for users to search vehicle inventory by year, make, and model and view useful vehicle information without an overly complicated search experience.

Marketing Plan

Marketing Strategy

CarFinder will primarily use low cost digital marketing to reach vehicle shoppers, researchers, and automotive enthusiasts. The strategy combines SEO, social media, automotive communities, direct sharing, QR code promotion, and professional networking. Using multiple channels will help increase awareness while allowing me to compare which methods bring the most engaged users to CarFinder.

Marketing Goals

- Generate traffic after launch.
- Build awareness among vehicle shoppers and automotive enthusiasts.
- Encourage users to search by year, make, and model.
- Increase vehicle detail page views.
- Identify which marketing channels perform best.
- Collect feedback and analytics to improve CarFinder.

Initial launch data will be used as a baseline for setting more specific growth goals in the future.

Marketing Methods

Method	Strategy	Cost / Resources	Audience Fit	Success Measure
SEO Search	Optimize CarFinder for specific vehicle related searches.	Free keyword research, metadata, content updates	Reaches users already researching vehicles	Organic traffic, impressions, clicks, searches
Social Media	Share short posts and videos demonstrating CarFinder's features.	Free screenshots, videos, and posts	Reaches vehicle shoppers and enthusiasts	Link clicks, referrals, engagement
Automotive Communities	Share CarFinder in relevant automotive groups and request feedback.	Free community participation	Direct access to automotive audiences	Referrals, searches, feedback
Direct Sharing	Share the live application with classmates, friends, and professional contacts.	Free live link and launch message	Helps build an initial user base	Visits, searches, repeat users
QR Codes	Use branded QR cards or flyers that link directly to CarFinder.	About \$10-\$30 for printing	Provides an offline way to reach users	QR scans and campaign visits
GitHub / Professional Networks	Share the project, repository, and development	Free GitHub, README, screenshots	Reaches developers, recruiters, and	Repository visits and project clicks

	process professionally.		technology professionals	
--	----------------------------	--	-----------------------------	--

Primary Marketing Focus

The main focus will be SEO, social media, and automotive communities because these methods reach people who already have an interest in vehicles. Organic search can provide long term visibility, while social media and automotive communities can generate quicker exposure and feedback during launch.

Out of the Box Marketing Ideas

Find Your Car QR Cards: Create branded QR cards with a message such as "What car are you looking for?" that link directly to CarFinder.

CarFinder Search Challenge: Encourage users to search for their current car, first car, or dream car to increase interaction with the application's main feature.

Car Meet Feedback: Share CarFinder at local automotive events and ask enthusiasts to test the application and suggest future features.

Measuring Marketing Success

Marketing success will focus on both traffic and actual CarFinder usage. I will track total and returning visitors, traffic sources, organic and referral traffic, searches performed, filter usage, vehicle detail views, no result searches, and QR code visits. Comparing these measurements will show which marketing channels bring users who actually interact with the application.

SEO Plan

SEO Methodology

CarFinder's SEO strategy will focus on specific search phrases that match the application's actual features instead of broad terms such as "cars" or "vehicles." Keywords will be selected based on user search intent, relevance to CarFinder's features, long tail specificity, and content fit.

The strategy will consider multiple search engines, including Google and Bing, and performance will be reviewed after launch using search impressions, clicks, queries, and user engagement.

Target Keywords

#	Keyword	Reason
1	Search cars by year make and model	Directly matches CarFinder's main search feature
2	Find cars by make and model	Targets users narrowing vehicle choices
3	Vehicle search by year make model	Matches the primary search workflow
4	Search vehicle inventory online	Targets online inventory searches
5	Browse cars by make and model	Targets users exploring vehicle options
6	Find vehicle information online	Targets general vehicle research
7	Car model search tool	Positions CarFinder as a vehicle search tool
8	Search cars by year and model	Targets users researching specific model years
9	Vehicle make and model finder	Closely matches CarFinder's functionality
10	Online car inventory search	Targets users looking for vehicle inventory
11	Search cars and view vehicle details	Connects search with vehicle detail pages
12	Car finder by year, make and model	Directly connects the CarFinder concept to its main feature

Keywords will be incorporated naturally into relevant content instead of being repeatedly added only for search rankings.

Metadata Plan

Page	SEO Title	Meta Description
Home/Search	CarFinder Search Cars by Year, Make and Model	Search vehicle inventory by year, make, and model and explore available vehicle information with CarFinder.
Search Results	Vehicle Search Results CarFinder	Browse vehicle results based on your selected year, make, and model and view available vehicle details.
Vehicle Details	[Year] [Make] [Model] Details CarFinder	View available price, mileage, VIN, description, and details for this [Year] [Make] [Model].
Add Vehicle	Add Vehicle Inventory CarFinder	Add vehicle information including year, make, model, price, mileage, VIN, and listing details.
Favorites	Favorite Vehicles CarFinder	View saved vehicles in CarFinder for easier access during vehicle research.

Content & Technical SEO Updates

- Add clear H1 and H2 headings throughout the application.
- Add homepage text explaining CarFinder and its search features.
- Use descriptive year, make, and model information on vehicle pages.
- Add descriptive alt text to vehicle images.
- Use clean, readable URLs.
- Improve internal links between search results and vehicle details.
- Create and submit a sitemap after deployment.
- Continue reviewing mobile responsiveness and performance.
- Use keywords naturally and avoid keyword stuffing.

Analytics Plan

Analytics Methodology

CarFinder's analytics strategy will answer two main questions. How are users finding CarFinder, and what are they doing after they arrive? Analytics will also measure searches, vehicle views, navigation, and other important interactions.

Analytics Tools Researched

Tool	Strength	Limitation	CarFinder Fit
Google Analytics 4	Tracks traffic, sources, engagement, and custom events	Can be complex	Best for overall traffic and CarFinder events
Microsoft Clarity	Heatmaps and session recordings	Less focused on traffic acquisition	Helps identify usability and navigation problems
Google Search Console	Tracks queries, impressions, clicks, and indexing	Google Search only	Measures Google SEO performance
Bing Webmaster Tools	Keyword, indexing, sitemap, and search data	Primarily Bing focused	Supports SEO beyond Google

Selected Analytics Stack

CarFinder will use Google Analytics 4, Microsoft Clarity, Google Search Console, and Bing Webmaster Tools. GA4 will track traffic and important events, while Clarity will help identify how visitors interact with the interface. Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools will monitor organic search visibility.

What Will Be Measured

Acquisition

Visitors, traffic sources, organic traffic, referrals, direct traffic, and QR campaigns

Vehicle Engagement

Vehicle detail views, selections from results, returning users, and future Favorite interactions

Search Engagement

Search submissions, year/make/model filters, successful searches, no result searches

SEO & User Experience

Search impressions, clicks, queries, click patterns, scrolling, and navigation behavior

Key Performance Indicators

The main KPIs will be completed searches, vehicle detail views, no result searches, organic visits, referral traffic, returning visitors, search impressions and clicks, and QR/social campaign engagement. These measurements focus on meaningful use of CarFinder rather than page views alone.

Analytics Implementation Plan

1. Configure Google Analytics 4 for the production website.
2. Add GA4 tracking and custom events for searches, filters, no result searches, and vehicle detail views.
3. Add Microsoft Clarity for heatmaps and session recordings.
4. Verify CarFinder with Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools.
5. Submit the production sitemap.
6. Create campaign links for social media and QR code marketing.
7. Review analytics during Beta testing and after launch.
8. Use the results to guide future improvements.

Weekly Status Update

Completed Last Week

I continued developing CarFinder and preparing it for the next stage of the Capstone. The core vehicle search, vehicle details, inventory creation, navigation, NHTSA API integration, responsive layout, and major user flows are functional. I also completed use case testing and continued organizing the project through GitHub.

Currently Working On

This week, I am completing the Marketing, SEO, and Analytics plans and reviewing CarFinder for the changes needed before launch. This includes researching marketing methods, selecting SEO keywords and metadata, and comparing analytics tools.

Next Week

Next week, I will begin formal Beta testing, collect user feedback, and make necessary improvements. I will also begin implementing the approved SEO and analytics changes and continue tracking development through GitHub.

Overall Status

CarFinder is on schedule and moving from development into testing and launch preparation. The main remaining work includes Beta testing, implementing SEO and analytics, addressing user feedback, and completing final improvements.

SWOT Analysis

STRENGTHS

- Simple year/make/model search
- NHTSA API integration
- Responsive design
- Functional search and vehicle details

WEAKNESSES

- Limited initial inventory
- Low brand awareness
- Inventory currently uses local storage
- Favorites/accounts are incomplete

OPPORTUNITIES

- Automotive SEO
- Social and automotive communities
- VIN, recall, and safety data
- Database backed inventory

THREATS

- Large automotive competitors
- Users may expect purchasing features
- Dependence on external API data
- Scope creep before launch

RISE Self Assessment

Reflect

This week showed me that building a working application is only part of launching a project. CarFinder also needs a strategy for reaching users and measuring whether they are actually using the application as intended.

Inquire

During Beta testing, I want to see whether users understand the year, make, and model search without needing instructions and what they do when a search returns no results.

Suggest

The next step should be testing the current experience, implementing the approved SEO and analytics changes, and fixing issues found during Beta testing before adding more features.

Elevate

CarFinder does not need the most features to be successful. The priority is making the main search experience easy to understand and using feedback and analytics to guide future development.

References

Google Search Central. (2025). SEO starter guide: The basics. Google for Developers.
<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/fundamentals/seo-starter-guide>

Google Search Central. (2025). Influencing your title links in search results. Google for Developers.
<https://developers.google.com/search/docs/appearance/title-link>

Microsoft. (n.d.). Keyword research. Bing Webmaster Tools.
<https://www.bing.com/webmasters/help/keyword-research-628070b6>

Google. (n.d.). Events. Google Analytics Help.
<https://support.google.com/analytics/answer/9356037>

Google. (n.d.). Performance report (Search results): Overview and basic setup. Google Search Console Help.
<https://support.google.com/webmasters/answer/7576553>

Microsoft. (n.d.). Microsoft Clarity: Free heatmaps & session recordings.
<https://clarity.microsoft.com/>

Microsoft. (n.d.). Bing Webmaster Tools.
<https://www.bing.com/webmasters/about>

National Highway Traffic Safety Administration. (n.d.). Vehicle API. U.S. Department of Transportation.
<https://vpic.nhtsa.dot.gov/api/>